



“Strategy Fundamentals” by Dave Jordaan USA Cycling ‘Level 1’ Coach

A cycling race **tactic** is a specific plan by a single or group of riders in support of a particular **strategy**. The **strategy** is the overall game plan and the **tactics** are the many little movements it takes during the game to achieve the goals of your **strategy**. Plan A is to have a pre-race strategy. Plan B is to make Plan A work! All racing **tactics** can be categorized as follows;

- **POSITIVE** (work done for team or individual goal - effort placed on advancing pace/ group)
- **NEUTRAL** (Holding your place but neither advancing nor blocking the outcome)
- **NEGATIVE** (Working against or attempting to undermine efforts of other teams or individuals – reacting to other riders moves and therefore works against your result)

The “**BIG 5**” race tactics: **ATTACKING, BLOCKING, CHASING, BRIDGING and SPRINTING.** I will send you specific sheets on these but 1st and foremost you need to fully understand the following;

Fundamental tactics that apply to every race:

- ✓ Always remember what the overall planned **strategy** is. You can change **tactics** as long as it does not affect the **strategy**.
- ✓ Never go to a race to lose unless either you or your team cannot physically support any kind of winning action – when you would then race to place (even if it is a ‘training’ race’)
- ✓ Never chase your own teammate.
- ✓ Never do your competition's work for them
- ✓ Never underestimate your competition's strength.
- ✓ Always try to toughen every race you enter.
- ✓ Every ounce of energy you expend must be to your own or your teams’ benefit.
- ✓ Racing aggressively is your best weapon.
- ✓ No matter how hard you are hurting do not let anyone know i.e. look relaxed and SMILE

Fundamental facts that apply to every race are;

- 1) If you are not 30% stronger than the rider or group on your wheel then you should not be ahead of that rider or group unless you have a special purpose for pulling at that point.
- 2) Only 30% of a peleton, usually only the riders in the front 10 to 15, are a major factor during a bicycle race. The rest of the riders are
 - Sitting in to save it for the finish.
 - Barely strong enough to hold on at the back.
 - Injured or sick and are trying to recover.

These 3 groups of riders are most often the causes of crashes so if you want to increase your safety make certain that you ride in the front 1/3rd while at the same time staying off the front (unless you have a really good reason to be up there).

- 3) A break must have at least one team rider in it or it will almost certainly come back
 - 4) The peleton will often lose focus on a break which is more than;
 - Women's Cat 3/4, Juniors and Cat 4/5: 20 to 25 seconds ahead
 - Men's Cat 3 Women's Cat 1/2: 30 to 40 seconds ahead
 - Men's Cat 1/2: 50-60 seconds ahead
 - Pros: Never
- Learn to judge these times i.e. how long your lead has to be in order to stay away in a break